

P.S. RAGHAVAN
Ex-chairman, National Security Advisory Board

"Excluding Russian banks from SWIFT is the financial equivalent of pressing the nuclear button, rarely employed"



ANDREW SMALL
German Marshall Fund, US

"It's not just a Russia question but a Russia enabled by China one. Europe's been explicit about Beijing's involvement"



EMMANUEL LENAIN
French ambassador to India

"Sanctions have made life difficult for Russia, the impact visible in the rouble sinking by a margin of 30 per cent"



HARISH SHRINGLA
Foreign secretary

"Our foremost priority was to get our students out. We put all our equities in that direction"

dependent on Russia for its defence purchases, both for conventional and strategic needs. Over 90 per cent of equipment for the Indian army's requirements, 65 per cent for the air force's needs and 41 per cent for the navy's, is of Russian origin. In addition, deals worth over $15 billion are in the pipeline, for everything from ships, aircraft and tanks to assault rifles and missiles. On the list is the controversial Triumf S-400 air defence system that has come under US scrutiny as it falls under CAATSA or the Countering America's Adversaries through Sanctions Act (see *Our Russian Arms*).

WHAT PUTIN DID NOT EXPECT WAS THE UNITED EUROPEAN RESPONSE AND THE SWIFT SANCTIONS THEY WOULD RETALIATE WITH

Menon believes all these constitute good reasons for India not to choose sides in this battle. "The US just cannot replace Russia for us," he says. "Are the Americans willing to give you a nuclear submarine on lease, as Russia has done? Or help build nuclear reactors for India long before the Nuclear Suppliers Group permitted it, as Russia did? Apart from that, Russia is allowing us to co-develop state-of-the-art fighter aircraft while the US has so far not put that on the table." Varma points to the more than billion dollars worth of small parts for defence equipment India is dependent on Russia for. "Just to cite an odd example, can your MiG29 fly without wiper blade replacement parts?" he asks.

While India's defence relations with Russia remain robust, regular bilateral trade is far below potential. Last year, trade between the two countries totalled $9.4 billion compared to the $113 billion with the US, India's largest trading partner. Imports from Russia account for just 1.5 per cent of India's total and are dominated by crude oil and fertilisers. Exports to Russia are a minuscule 0.8 per cent of the total, comprising largely electrical equipment and pharmaceutical products. However, India has made significant investments in Russian oilfields to meet its future energy requirements. With several Russian banks